

# THE BENCH IS YOUR LAB.

How to use the six-row skill framework to turn observation into your greatest competitive advantage.

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**If you are not in the starting rotation right now — this page is for you.**

Not as a consolation. Not as a pep talk. As a competitive strategy.

Every roster has gaps. Not because the athletes ahead of you are bad — but because no athlete is complete. Every starting position has a physical weakness and an intangible gap. A skill that breaks down under pressure. A mental quality that disappears when the moment gets big.

**Your job is to find those gaps. Then fill them.**

Not by chasing the starter. Not by hoping she fails. By training the exact quality the team needs — and proving in every practice rep that you have it.

## WHAT A GAP LOOKS LIKE

1

### PRESSURE INTANGIBLE GAP

*The starting libero plays clean in warm-up but crumbles at game point when the gym gets loud.*

INTANGIBLE GAP: COMPOSURE UNDER PRESSURE

2

## TECHNICAL SKILL GAP

*The starting outside hitter cannot pass. The team hides her in serve receive every rotation.*

INTANGIBLE GAP: SERVE RECEIVE / PLATFORM CONSISTENCY

3

## COMMUNICATION GAP

*The starting setter goes quiet after a bad set. Nobody calls the ball. The team loses its floor.*

INTANGIBLE GAP: LEADERSHIP AND COMMUNICATION UNDER PRESSURE

4

## RECOVERY GAP

*The starting middle makes one error and it follows her for three straight rotations.*

INTANGIBLE GAP: RESET SPEED / MISTAKE RESPONSE

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*These are not criticisms of your teammates. They are observations. And observation — done right — is training.*

## THE SIX-ROW SKILL FRAMEWORK — FOR BENCH ATHLETES

You chose three focus skills in Zero In. For each one — fill in all six rows. Then look at the depth chart. Ask yourself: where does this skill or intangible show up as a gap in the rotation ahead of me?

**1**

### THE PHYSICAL SKILL I AM DEVELOPING

The specific technical skill from your satisfaction wheel. Your exact words.

**2**

### MY SATISFACTION RATING AT THE START OF THE SEASON

Your honest number from the wheel. Not where you want to be — where you are.

**3**

### THE ONE ACTION I IDENTIFIED TO IMPROVE IT

The specific drill or technical focus you named. What you are doing in every rep.

**4**

### THE INTANGIBLE BEHIND THIS SKILL

The mental quality. Composure. Focus. Communication. Resilience. Your word.

**5**

### WHERE THIS INTANGIBLE GAP LIVES IN THE ROTATION AHEAD OF ME

Look at the depth chart. Where does the team need this quality most? Who is the starter? What breaks down for them under pressure?

**6**

### HOW I WILL PROVE I HAVE IT — IN PRACTICE

Not in games. In practice. What specific behavior will you show in every rep that demonstrates you can fill this gap?

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## OBSERVATION IS TRAINING

**When you are watching from the sideline you are not sitting out. You are scouting.**

### Watch through your skills.

Every rep, every rotation — watch for your three focus skills in action. Where are they present? Where are they missing?

### Watch for the gap.

Where does the intangible you are building disappear under pressure? Which rotation? Which moment? Which score?

### Watch for the moment.

When does the gap cost the team? That is the moment you are preparing for.

### Visualize yourself filling it.

Do not just watch. See yourself in that position. How do you respond? What does your composure look like when the gym gets loud?

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#### THE STANDARD

## THE ATHLETE WHO GETS THE MOMENT IS THE ONE WHO WAS READY FOR IT.

- You are not waiting for your chance. You are building toward it.
- Every practice rep is a proving ground — not for your coach, for yourself.
- The athlete who has been watching, preparing, and training with the gap in mind is a completely different athlete from the one who has been watching the clock.
- You vs. You. That is the only comparison that matters.

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*"The bench is not a punishment. It is a perspective. Use it."*

— MazePerformance MindSystem